in the region's colonization. [61] Indeed, colonization by European powers of the entire Indian subcontinent represented a transition to a new phase in India's international history.

Guns and Ships: European Arrivals, 1498–1857

In the medieval period, visitors to India from Europe were few and far between. They included the celebrated Venetian traveller Marco Polo, followed by his compatriot Niccolò de' Conti who stayed in Vijayanagara. In the late fifteenth century, the Russian Afanasy Nikitin came to Bidar and western India for some years. There was an indirect exchange of material culture: for example, a first-millennium CE bronze Buddha statue, possibly from Kashmir, has been found in a Viking hoard in the trading town of Helgö in today's Sweden. But direct interactions between India, on the one hand, and Western and Northern Europe on the other, were virtually non-existent before the arrival in 1498 of Vasco da Gama in Calicut on the Malabar coast.

The arrival of the Portuguese significantly accelerated contacts between India and Europe. Europeans interacted with Indians originally in Arabic, but also quickly learned to communicate in Persian, Malayalam, Konkani, and Tamil. Their early interests in India extended to medicine, botany, navigation, and religion. [62] In 1505, Francisco de Almeida was dispatched as the first Portuguese viceroy of the Estado da Índia, marking the start of European colonialism in India. The military superiority of Europeans was not immediately apparent, at least not in every respect. For example, the Portuguese military leader Afonso de Albuquerque wrote in 1513 that Indian gunsmiths—who had adopted Ottoman technologies—were producing higher quality firearms than their German counterparts and promptly dispatched some of these gunsmiths to Lisbon. [63] At the same time, after 1520, the Portuguese engaged in piracy against Indian vessels and tried to preserve a monopoly in European trade in the Indian Ocean. This even necessitated an agreement in the Indian Ocean with the Ottomans, who had threatened Portuguese stations in Muscat and Hormuz